

efficiency. This period also saw the introduction of block rakes where entire trainloads of consignments such as coal were booked making freight movement efficient and effective. The impact was immediate with the railways registering a marked growth in goods transportation in 1981–82 when it went up by 13 per cent to 221 million tonnes.

CONCOR's role

The end of the decade saw the formation of the Container Corporation of India (CONCOR) in 1989, as container traffic – export–import and domestic – set new trends in railway freight traffic. CONCOR, a Public Sector Undertaking, played a significant role in subsequent years. It took charge of the inland container depots that were previously with the Indian Railways and commissioned several more to meet the growing demand. It acted as a carrier, while providing 94 per cent of the transport through the railway network, and as a terminal and warehouse operator.

Today, the Indian Railways operates up to 7,000 freight trains daily and the traffic accounts for nearly two-thirds of its revenue. Increasing innovations in operating practices, new wagons, improvements in track structures with enhanced safety parameters have also contributed to a steady increase in profits from freight. The upcoming [dedicated freight corridors](#) and an increased focus on freight will boost CONCOR's purview, as it provides ready infrastructure and easy connectivity between the ports and the hinterland.